back and her business grew by leaps and bounds. In less than a decade, she had built a business empire with an annual turnover of Rs 300 crore.

Tata's Troubles

In 2007, an anonymous complaint reached Finance Minister P. Chidambaram, alleging that Radia was working for a foreign intelligence agency and conducting dubious business deals. Although according to government guidelines, anonymous complaints are not generally to be acted upon, 'on the basis of specific information received from the CBDT [Central Board of Direct Taxes], the telephone lines of Ms Radia and some of her associates were put under observation after obtaining permission from the Home Secretary'.

Radia's conversations with Ratan were mainly focused on advocacy for Tata Teleservices (TTSL). The tapes contained nothing that suggested alleged manipulation by the Tatas of the 2G spectrum allocation that was completed several months before the wiretaps. Radia defended her advocacy of the interests of the Tatas to the CBI, declaring that she was representing TTSL to ensure that it got a 'level playing field'.

Simultaneously, Ratan mounted a vigorous defence against the accusations that TTSL was involved in the so-called '2G spectrum scam'. He refuted all allegations that it had been unduly favoured. On the other hand, he asserted that Tata companies had suffered on account of corruption and arbitrariness. His assertions found vindication, ironically, in the unlikeliest of places—the transcripts of the taped conversations.

In the tapes, Radia could be heard saying that TTSL might not get the required permission as the communication minister was 'hellbent' on favouring another telecom company. This revelation contradicted the contention that Radia, in collusion with A. Raja, had struck an unduly favourable deal for the group.

Tata Fights Back

Ratan does not take allegations of misdemeanour lightly, whether on his part or that of the group. He is also a strong advocate of minimalistic government and maximum individual freedom. For him, the protection of